MUSTARD SEED

Action Plan & Implementation Roadmap

A step-by-step guide for building the business from scratch

Solo Founder | Bootstrap | Pilot-First

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Companion document to the Mustard Seed Business Plan V2.0

Table of Contents

1. Pre-Launch Checklist (Before Day 1)
2. Phase 1. Foundation (Months 1–3)
3. Phase 2. First Clients (Months 4–6)
4. Phase 3. Prove the Model (Months 7–12)
5. Phase 4. Scale (Year 2+)
6. Decision Gates & Kill Criteria
7. Budget & Spending Timeline
8. Risk Register & Contingencies
9. Key Milestones Calendar
10. Weekly Rhythm & Time Allocation

1. Pre-Launch Checklist

Complete these before committing any money or approaching clients. Estimated time: 2–4 weeks.

1.1 Legal & Administrative

- ☐ Register company with Companies House (Ltd) (~£50 online)
- ☐ Open a business bank account (Starling, Tide, or Monzo Business (free))
- ☐ Register for HMRC Self Assessment or Corporation Tax
- ☐ Get professional indemnity insurance (~£200–400/year for consulting)
- ☐ Draft standard equity agreement template. Use Seedlegals (~£500) or DIY with legal templates
- ☐ Register ICO data protection (if handling client data) (£40/year)

Estimated cost: £500–£1,000

Timeline. Week 1–2

1.2 Brand & Digital Presence

- ☐ Secure domain name (mustardseed.co.uk or similar) (~£10/year)
- ☐ Create a simple landing page. Use Carrd.co (£19/year) or free WordPress
- ☐ Set up professional email (Google Workspace (£5/month))
- ☐ Create LinkedIn company page
- ☐ Design basic logo (Canva (free) or Fiverr (£20–50))
- ☐ Write a one-page service overview PDF

Estimated cost: £50–£150

Timeline. Week 2–3

1.3 Service Preparation

- ☐ Build the diagnostic framework (business health assessment template)
- ☐ Create a standard onboarding pack for new portfolio companies
- ☐ Design pricing sheets for training and financial advisory services
- ☐ Prepare a portfolio company selection scorecard (criteria for choosing clients)
- ☐ Write template equity agreement with staged milestone clauses
- ☐ Create a simple CRM tracker (Excel or free HubSpot)

Estimated cost: £0 (your time only)

Timeline. Week 2–4

1.4 Network & Pipeline

- ☐ Identify 15–20 target businesses (through churches, business networks, LinkedIn)

- ☐ Join 2–3 faith-based business networks (CREO, Navigators NEC, local church business groups)
- ☐ Attend 2–3 startup/SME events in your area
- ☐ Reach out to 5 businesses for informal conversations (not selling (learning))
- ☐ Build a simple referral pipeline tracker

Estimated cost: £0–£100 (event tickets)

Timeline. Week 3–4

2. Phase 1: Foundation (Months 1–3)

Goal. Generate first revenue from consulting and training while signing first portfolio company.

2.1 Revenue Actions

Priority. Generate cash flow immediately through fee-based services.

- Offer business health diagnostics as a paid service (£300–£500 per diagnostic)
- Run first training workshop (target 5–10 attendees at £150–£300 each)
- Take on 1–2 hourly consulting clients (£75–£150/hr) for immediate income
- Offer financial advisory to 1–2 clients (£300–£500 per engagement)

Month 1 target: £1,000–£2,000 from consulting/training

Month 2 target: £2,000–£3,000 (repeat clients + new leads)

Month 3 target: £3,000–£4,000 (training + consulting + first equity signing)

2.2 Portfolio Development

- Shortlist 5 businesses from your pipeline using the selection scorecard
- Run diagnostic assessments with top 3 candidates
- Present partnership proposals to 2 strongest candidates
- Sign first portfolio company (3-month pilot, 3–5% equity stake)
- Begin embedded work (2–3 days/week with first portfolio company)

2.3 Marketing & Outreach

- Post weekly on LinkedIn about small business growth (establish authority)
- Share diagnostic insights (anonymised) as thought leadership
- Ask first consulting clients for testimonials
- Attend 1 networking event per month

2.4 Time Allocation (Solo Founder)

Activity	Days/Week	Hours/Week	Notes
Portfolio company (embedded)	2–3	16–24	Once first company signed (Month 2+)
Consulting clients	1–2	8–16	Pays the bills immediately
Training/workshops	0.5	4	Monthly workshops + prep
Admin/marketing/pipeline	0.5–1	4–8	LinkedIn, networking, CRM
TOTAL	5	~40	Sustainable founder workload

2.5 End-of-Phase Checkpoint

Before moving to Phase 2, answer these honestly:

☐ Have I generated at least £5,000 in fee revenue in 3 months?

- ☐ Is my first portfolio company signed and progressing?
- ☐ Do I have a pipeline of 3+ interested businesses?
- ☐ Am I working sustainable hours (not burning out)?

If 3/4 are YES → move to Phase 2. If not → extend Phase 1 by 1–2 months.

3. Phase 2: First Clients (Months 4–6)

Goal. Establish 2–3 portfolio companies, build case studies, and reach £10K quarterly revenue.

3.1 Portfolio Expansion

- Sign second portfolio company (3-month pilot, 3–5% equity)
- First portfolio company. Review KPIs and decide on Stage 2 equity (3–5% additional)
- Begin conversations with 3rd candidate
- Document everything. Processes, frameworks, results (this becomes your IP)

3.2 Revenue Growth

- Increase training workshops to twice monthly
- Raise consulting rates by 10–15% if demand supports it
- Introduce group training sessions (higher revenue per hour)
- Target: £10,000–£12,000 quarterly revenue from fees alone

3.3 Faith Network Development

- Partner with 1–2 churches for business ministry events
- Join or establish a local faith-and-business meetup
- Connect with CREO Ventures or Navigators NEC for referrals
- Position Mustard Seed as the 'go-to' for faith-driven entrepreneurs

3.4 Systems & Processes

- Create a standard 90-day diagnostic playbook (repeatable for each new company)
- Build a KPI tracking dashboard for portfolio companies
- Automate invoicing and time tracking
- Write case study from first portfolio company (with permission)

3.5 End-of-Phase Checkpoint

☐ Am I generating £10K+ per quarter from fees?

☐ Do I have 2+ active portfolio companies?

☐ Has my first portfolio company hit at least 1 milestone?

☐ Is demand exceeding my solo capacity? (this triggers Phase 3 hiring)

If 3/4 are YES → move to Phase 3. If demand isn't exceeding capacity, extend Phase 2.

4. Phase 3: Prove the Model (Months 7–12)

Goal. Reach £40K annual revenue, prove the embedded model works, prepare for scaling.

4.1 Growth & Hiring Decision

Hire ONLY if ALL three conditions are met:

- You have 4+ portfolio companies (or demand for them)
- Fee revenue covers your costs + the new hire's salary for 3 months
- You are consistently working >50 hours/week and turning away work

If conditions aren't met, continue solo. There is no shame in a profitable solo practice.

4.2 If Hiring: First Consultant

- Part-time or contract initially (£25–£35K pro-rata, or £150–£250/day contractor)
- Focus. Someone who complements your weaknesses (finance person if you're ops-focused, or vice versa)
- Trial period: 3 months, paid from fee revenue (not savings)
- They manage 2 portfolio companies while you manage 2 + business development

4.3 Portfolio Milestones

- First portfolio company. Complete Stage 2, begin Stage 3 (independence milestones)
- Total portfolio: 3–4 companies with measurable growth metrics
- Publish 2+ case studies
- First equity return. Even a small dividend or valuation increase validates the model

4.4 Revenue Targets

Revenue Stream	Monthly Target	Annual (Y1)	% of Revenue
Consulting fees	£1,500	£18,000	45%
Training workshops	£800	£9,600	24%
Financial advisory	£500	£6,000	15%
Diagnostic services	£500	£6,000	15%
TOTAL	£3,300	~£40,000	100%

Note. Equity value (£30K estimated at year-end) is NOT counted as revenue (it's long-term upside.)

4.5 End-of-Year Checkpoint

- ☐ Did I hit £35K+ in fee revenue?
- ☐ Do I have 3+ portfolio companies with documented progress?
- ☐ Is at least one portfolio company ready for independence (Stage 3)?
- ☐ Do I have a repeatable playbook that someone else could follow?

If YES to most → proceed to Year 2 scaling. If not → consolidate and extend.

5. Phase 4: Scale (Year 2+)

Goal. Grow to 6–8 portfolio companies, £90K revenue, and establish Mustard Seed as a brand.

5.1 Team Growth (Trigger-Based)

Trigger	Action	Cost	Funded By
4+ companies, >50hr weeks	Hire consultant #1 (part-time)	£25–30K	Fee revenue
6+ companies	Hire financial specialist (part-time)	£28–32K	Fee revenue
Revenue >£150K	Consider small seed round (£50–100K)	Dilution	Angel/faith investors
8+ companies	Consider full-time ops hire	£30–35K	Fee + equity returns

Golden rule. Every hire must be funded by existing revenue, not by projections.

5.2 Revenue Expansion

- Introduce tiered training programmes (basic → advanced → masterclass)
- Launch online/digital training (recurring revenue, lower delivery cost)
- Consider a small fund structure for external investors (Year 3+)
- Cross-referral between portfolio companies (network effect)

5.3 Brand & Reputation

- Speak at 2–3 events per year (church business events, startup conferences)
- Publish annual 'Impact Report' showing portfolio company growth
- Build relationships with angel investors and faith-driven funds
- Media coverage. Christian business publications, local press, startup media

6. Decision Gates & Kill Criteria

Every phase has a 'continue or pivot' checkpoint. These gates are non-negotiable.

Gate	Timing	Continue If...	Pivot/Pause If...	Kill If...
Gate 1	Month 3	£5K+ revenue, 1 company signed	Revenue <£3K, no companies	Zero revenue, zero pipeline
Gate 2	Month 6	£10K+ quarterly, 2+ companies	Revenue flat, no growth	Losing money, clients leaving
Gate 3	Month 12	£35K+ annual, 3+ companies	Revenue <£25K	Can't cover basic costs
Gate 4	Month 18	£60K+ annual, clear demand	Growth stalled	Model not working at scale

6.1 What 'Pivot' Means

- If portfolio model isn't working. Become a pure consulting firm (still profitable)
- If equity isn't attractive to clients. Switch to revenue-share model
- If faith-niche is too small. Expand to general small business market
- If solo model is maxed. Partner with another consultant (equity partnership)

Mustard Seed is designed so that the worst-case outcome is a profitable consulting business. There is no scenario where you lose everything if you follow the gates.

7. Budget & Spending Timeline

Total startup cost: ~£1,000–£1,500. All funded from savings or first month's revenue.

7.1 Pre-Launch Spending (Before Month 1)

Item	Cost	When	Essential?
Company registration	£50	Week 1	Yes
Professional indemnity insurance	£200–400	Week 1	Yes
Equity agreement template (Seedlegals)	£500	Week 2	Yes
Domain + email	£80/year	Week 2	Yes
Logo (Canva/Fiverr)	£0–50	Week 3	Nice to have
Landing page (Carrd)	£19/year	Week 3	Nice to have
ICO registration	£40/year	Week 4	If handling data
TOTAL	£890–£1,140		

7.2 Monthly Running Costs (Solo Phase)

Item	Monthly Cost	Annual	Notes
Google Workspace	£5	£60	Professional email
Insurance	£20–35	£240–420	Professional indemnity
Software (CRM, tools)	£0–30	£0–360	Free tier where possible
Travel/networking	£50–100	£600–1,200	Events, client visits
Marketing/content	£0–50	£0–600	Mostly organic/free
TOTAL	£75–£220	£900–£2,640	

At £75–£220/month running costs, you need just 1–2 consulting hours per month to stay alive. The business is nearly impossible to kill if you keep costs this low.

8. Risk Register & Contingencies

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Can't find portfolio companies	Medium	High	Continue consulting-only — still profitable
Portfolio company fails	Medium	Medium	Staged equity limits loss; diversify across 3+ companies
Client disputes equity terms	Low	High	Use Seedlegals template; mutual exit rights at every stage
Burnout (solo founder)	High	High	Strict 40hr/week; hire trigger-based; take holidays
Market downturn	Medium	Medium	SMEs still need help in downturns; consulting demand may increase
Competitor enters niche	Low	Low	First-mover advantage; faith network loyalty; embedded model hard to copy
Regulatory changes (FCA)	Low	Medium	Monitor; financial advisory may need FCA permissions depending on scope
Cash flow gaps	Medium	High	Keep 3 months expenses in reserve (£600–£1,000); invoice promptly

9. Key Milestones Calendar

Month	Milestone	Success Metric	Revenue Target
Pre-launch	Legal setup complete	Company registered, insurance live	—
Month 1	First paid client	£1K+ revenue	£1,000
Month 2	First portfolio company signed	Equity agreement executed	£2,000
Month 3	Gate 1 checkpoint	£5K+ cumulative revenue	£3,000
Month 4	First training workshop	5+ attendees, positive feedback	£3,000
Month 5	Second portfolio company	Signed + diagnostic complete	£3,500
Month 6	Gate 2 checkpoint	£10K+ quarterly, 2 companies	£4,000
Month 9	First case study published	Documented client success	£4,500
Month 12	Gate 3 checkpoint	£35K+ annual, 3+ companies	£5,000
Month 15	First hire (if triggered)	Demand exceeds solo capacity	£6,000
Month 18	Gate 4 checkpoint	£60K+ annual, scaling model	£7,000
Month 24	Year 2 target	£90K revenue, 6-8 companies	£8,000

10. Weekly Rhythm & Time Allocation

A suggested weekly structure for a solo founder. Adjust based on portfolio company needs.

Day	AM (9am–1pm)	PM (1pm–5pm)	Notes
Monday	Portfolio Company A	Portfolio Company A	Full day embedded
Tuesday	Portfolio Company A	Consulting clients	Split day
Wednesday	Portfolio Company B	Portfolio Company B	Full day embedded (from Month 2)
Thursday	Consulting clients	Training prep / delivery	Revenue-generating
Friday	Admin / marketing / CRM	Networking / pipeline	Business development
Weekend	OFF	OFF	Protect this — burnout kills businesses

Total: ~40 hours/week. If you consistently exceed 50 hours for 4+ weeks, that's a hiring trigger, not a sign of dedication.

Final Notes

This action plan is designed for one person with limited capital to build a real business. Every decision (from hiring to expansion). Is triggered by demand, not by ambition.

The beauty of the Mustard Seed model is that it cannot fail catastrophically. At worst, you run a profitable consulting practice. At best, you build a portfolio of growing businesses that generate equity returns for decades.

Start small. Prove the model. Scale what works. Stop what doesn't.

"From the smallest seed grows the largest tree."

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